against him to Maham Anaka, Adham Khan and Mirza Sharafuddin. Later, a council was held, and Maham's friend Shihabuddin Ahmad Khan was inducted into the circle of conspirators. On 18 March 1560, Akbar left Delhi, 'determined to do the deed'.[85]

From Abul Fazl's telling of the following days, however, it is hard to tell if what happened next was meticulously planned or entirely ad hoc; whether Akbar was directing the play, or merely guessing at its plot.

'Ostensibly', when Akbar left Delhi, it was to hunt. He didn't go very far, only across the Yamuna river. Then, as if by chance – '[as] he had no residence' there – he spent the night at the house of one Hakim Zambil.[86] So far so good; but Abul Fazl follows this straightforward narrative with a maddeningly suggestive non sequitur about Kamran's long-forgotten son:

> Since Bayram Khan had shown his affection and inner preference for Mirza Kamran's son Mirza Abu'l Qasim, and since the malevolents of Bayram's coterie kept him under a constant watch, the prince had been summoned to come via the river and participate in the hunt lest he . . . assist in any way those path beaters in the desert of sedition and corruption. In truth it was a good plan, and it happened exactly as it had been suggested to the emperor.[87]

One can only admire the sheer audacity of reintroducing Abul Qasim into the narrative five years after Akbar's cousin arrived in Kalanaur, never to be heard of again. There had been no evidence, all these years, to suggest that Bairam ever thought of replacing Akbar with his cousin; the regent may have curtailed Akbar's authority, but he had no plan to remove Akbar from his throne. Abul Fazl himself doesn't repeat the allegation, almost as if embarrassed by it.[88] The plan of summoning Abul Qasim 'had been suggested to the emperor', he writes, without saying by whom. Could it have been Maham?

Akbar's anaka came with Akbar on this hunting trip; and, according to Nizamuddin, she 'seized every opportunity of saying something to set the mind of the Emperor against Bairam Khan'. Was Abul Qasim brought sailing down the dark waters of the Yamuna to further Maham's case against Bairam: a hapless captive presented to Akbar as proof of conspiracy against him?

Is it possible, too, that Akbar didn't buy it? He had real resentments